4

''NEVAH HAD UH CROSS WORD''

Mammy and the Trope of Black Womanhood

The mammy image represents the normative yardstick used to evaluate all Black women's behavior.—Patricia Hill Collins

The image of mammy is so deeply rooted in American culture that it can be found in virtually every form of print and visual media.
—Sue K. Jewell

Unlike the white southern image of mammy, [the real mammy] is cunning, prone to poisoning her master, and not at all content with her lot.
—Barbara Christian

"Mother" is a trope that registers in various discursive terrains and is deployed for various aims. While black gay men sign the titular moniker as a way to subvert heteronormative gender roles and to declare their legitimacy (authenticity) as sexual citizens, black women's relationship to and deployment of the mother trope is peculiar to their unique history in the United States. Given that history, particularly regarding the exploitation of labor, black women's "mothering" is linked to a slave economy that forged a trajectory of black women's bodies as sites of labor and laboring.[1] Thus "mother" became coterminous with the more pejorative "mammy," which in the realm of domestic

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As Ella Surry's testimony suggests, being a "clever" trickster who can "play the game" is common among domestics, for they see their role playing as necessary to their survival in the white employer's home.

As with any racist stereotypic image, the mammy trope came to be taken as exemplary of "authentic" black womanhood. In other words, the attributes of the mythic figure became ontologically fastened to the black female bodies onto which they were projected. As I recount below, black women responded to this depiction of self in various and complicated ways. My grandmother, Mary Rhyne,[16] reveals some of the strategies domestics deployed to counter these depictions in her oral narrative about her days as a live-in domestic in the South. Through the act of performing her narrative, she reveals the ways in which the notion of black authenticity is contingent on context, history, and cultural values. Although the "mammy" prototype and the accompanying acquiescing behaviors attributed to her may be viewed as representative of authentic black womanhood in the white racist imaginary, my grandmother's narrative constructs a counterimage. Indeed, in her performance of self she supplants her own black authenticity on terms that correspond to her experiences as an aged black woman in a racist and sexist society.

Before I continue I wish to pause to say a word or two about my methodology. As I noted in the introduction, my goal throughout this book, and in each of the instances where I cite performed blackness, is to effect a performative dialogic ethnographic account. Toward that aim I wish to be ever cognizant of the ways in which my presence in the field affected the people I observe as well as my production of blackness. In this regard, this chapter on my grandmother warrants a more in-depth discussion given our personal relationship and the slipperiness of representing the life narrative of someone to whom I am closely related.

During the ethnographic encounter my role as audience to my grandmother's narrative varied. I listened to her stories as "grandson," as "ethnographer," and as "academic." I related to her and responded to what she said personally and culturally and in light of my academic and professional obligations and goals. My role-playing was, however, more impure than pure. I did not substitute one mask for another. Rather, my role-playing effected what Vincent Crapanzano identifies as a "bifurcated" sense of self.[17] According to Crapanzano, bifurcation

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is not a schizophrenic condition where one has no control over his or her actions. Instead, bifurcation refers to the conscious balancing act a researcher performs in the ethnographic encounter. This multiple subject position stems from the researcher's need to appear ethical and credible in the eyes of the academy and to be ethically responsible to the culture and the subject studied.

Within the ethnographic site of my grandmother's home, the information was processed in several different ways because of my multiple subject positions. For example, as I listened to and recorded my grandmother's life history, there were many moments of recognition because I either knew the people, places, or events to which she referred or because I had heard the story before. There were times during the interview when I mentally made notations about how what she was saying tied into a particular theory. There were still other times when I felt she was withholding information, and I tried to come up with an explanation for her reluctance. The process of being drawn into the story of a performer while maintaining a critical distance is the challenge of doing fieldwork and is that which makes it dialogic. It requires playing roles—that is, performing—and these roles effect shifting perspectives and shifting meanings, which destabilize "the expert."

In addition to interviewing my grandmother, I spent time getting to know her neighbors at her home at Tate Terrace, a public housing community for seniors in Kings Mountain, North Carolina. I also interviewed my grandmother's former employer, Mrs. Smith (see appendix B). My interactions with the community members and Mrs. Smith functioned to complicate or problematize my grandmother's narrative and my personal, cultural, and academic interpretation of it. My interactions with the residents of Tate Terrace revealed nuances about these people that sometimes contradicted my grandmother's construction of them—for example those whom she termed "pickles" (i.e., crazy) I found to be "sane." Likewise, sometimes my experience concurred with her views—for example, she declared that one neighbor was "homalsexual," and indeed he suggested that he was. Whereas Mary's attitude toward her relationship with Mrs. Smith was ambivalent, Mrs. Smith tended toward a romanticized or idealized depiction of the relationship. In addition, while conducting the interview with Mrs. Smith, I found it difficult to remain silent when hearing her refer

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to my grandmother as a "mammy." The interview was one moment in the process where my role as an academic/ethnographer transcended, to the point of silence, my role as grandson/black American.

My performance of heterosexuality or, at least my silence about my queerness, also affected the ethnographic encounter and implicated me in my grandmother's sometimes homophobic, sometimes ambivalent, attitude toward members of her community and toward homosexuality in general. For example, there was one resident, David, in whom my grandmother had a particular interest. I soon learned that David was a seventy-four-year-old white man who had to walk with the support of a walker, and who had moved to my grandmother's community from across town. But that was not the most important thing about David. Based on the fact that David "gardens, bakes pies, and keeps a clean house," my grandmother concluded that he was a "homalsexual." She followed with, "but some people can't he'p the way God made 'em." Whether or not her last statement was an opening for me to come out to her is unclear. Nonetheless, I never (and still have not) revealed my sexual orientation to my grandmother, and I have condoned her homophobic remarks about her neighbor, and even let her throw away pies that he made for me during my visit. On the other hand, my grandmother always made me thank him personally for the "gifts" he brought to me, and she asked me to run errands for him when he needed help—thus illustrating once again her ambivalent stance regarding sexuality and the ways in which I was implicated.

Finally, methodologically and otherwise I feel it is important to include in its entirety my grandmother's narrative from my interview with her in 1993 (see appendix A). Although it is positioned at the end of the text, its inclusion contextualizes my discussion of other topics and issues that I formulate throughout the chapter. Further, the inclusion of the narrative is also a political move. My desire is to allow my grandmother to speak for herself in her own words: this is my way of grounding theory in political praxis, of granting agency to the marginalized, and of helping to bring a silent voice from the margin to the center. Finally, including the entire narrative is a practical choice. Unlike traditional texts about which scholarly research is conducted, Mary's narrative is not available in bookstores or university libraries. If it were not included here, the reader would have no way of accessing it. I transcribed Mary's narrative using a performance-centered

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method in order to represent, as closely as possible, the sound and sense of her voice and gestures.[18] A full explanation of the symbols I use is given in the introduction to appendix A. Further, I have divided the full narrative into episodes; readers who wish to find the complete text of the material I quote in this chapter will find it in the appendix under the episode title.

Mary Rhyne's Labor History: 1955 to 1973

Mary Rhyne was born on February 26, 1914, in York County, South Carolina. The second oldest of five children, she was raised by her paternal grandfather on a small farm outside Gastonia, North Carolina. In 1930, she moved to Kings Mountain, North Carolina, where she met and married "Jim" McHaney. Together, they had five children—two girls and three boys. When she and Jim separated in 1949, Mary moved forty miles north to Hickory, North Carolina, where she moved in with her oldest daughter, Sarah. Shortly thereafter, however, she secured a place of her own in an apartment complex called the Embassy Apartments. She made a living by cleaning homes and by working part-time in a factory. By 1954, all of her children had relocated to Hickory.

Hickory residents Gene and Virginia Smith hired Mary as their domestic in fall 1955. Initially, Mary worked for the Smiths and for Virginia's parents, Mr. and Mrs. Friar, as a day worker. In spring 1956, after the birth of the Smiths's youngest daughter, Carol, Mary quit her job with the Friars and became a live-in domestic for the Smiths. For the next seventeen years (for a total of eighteen years of service) Mary lived with and worked for the Smiths.

Mary's workday included cleaning the Smiths' eight-room house, taking care of their lawn, and preparing all of their meals. She spent most of her day washing and ironing clothes, especially those of the children. She prepared only two meals a day, breakfast and dinner, because the children had lunch at school and the Smiths were at work. On the holidays, especially Thanksgiving and Christmas, the Smiths and their extended relatives helped Mary prepare the meal. During each of these holiday meals Mary was expected to sit at the dinner table and eat with the entire family, which she often did. Although

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Mary with her grandfather and siblings: (left to right) DeMaxie, Ervin, Ernest, Mary, and Taylor Adams, 1929.

the family helped Mary prepare the meal, they did not help her with the dishes, and thus she washed them by herself without the aid of a dishwasher.

More than anything else, Mary was the major care provider of the Smith children. During the weekdays, the Smiths' four children, Eddie, Patti, Jimmy, and Carol, were under Mary's supervision because their parents spent those days and nights forty-five minutes away in Shelby, North Carolina, where they owned and managed a hotel. During the week, Mary sent the children off to school, made sure that they did their homework, and prepared their meals. She also disciplined them at her discretion. On the weekends, the Smiths went to their home in Hickory to pick up Mary and the children and take them to Shelby. On Sunday evenings they were driven back to Hickory. Except for a few days out of the year (excluding holidays), Mary never had a day off. On some days, after she completed her chores at the Smiths', Mary was able to visit with her own family, who lived across town. This routine continued until 1970 when the Smiths sold their hotel, three years before Mary left their employ.[19]

Mary's tenure with the Smiths lasted through significant social and

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The Smith family: (left to right) Virginia Smith, Carol, Patti, Gene Smith, Jimmy, and Eddie. (standing, back center)

political events: the Civil Rights movement; the assassinations of John and Robert Kennedy, Martin Luther King Jr., and Malcolm X; and the sit-ins, to name a few. These events served as the backdrop of Mary's employment and marked a tenuous time in American history regarding race relations, particularly in the South. Despite this period of social unrest, Mary maintained an amicable and respectful relationship with her employers and their children. Indeed, according to Mary, they "nevah had uh cross word." Although Mr. Smith is now deceased, Mrs. Smith and her children keep in contact with Mary and speak fondly of her.[20] On many occasions Mrs. Smith has asked Mary to join her on trips to visit the Smith children, who live in various cities on the East Coast. The children, now parents themselves, send Mary Christmas and birthday cards and presents as well as pictures of their children.

In May 1973, a week before the youngest child, Carol, was to be married, Mary left the Smiths' home and never returned. According to both Mary and Mrs. Smith, Mary went to visit her sick brother in Washington, D.C. Because his sickness was life threatening, Mary remained in Washington for a period of two weeks. When she returned

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from visiting her brother, she decided not to go back to work for the Smiths. Rather than speak with the Smiths herself to inform them of her decision, she called one of the Smiths' neighbors and instructed her to tell the Smiths that she had decided to quit. For three years, between 1973 and 1976, Mary had little contact with her former employers. During those years, she worked in a shirt factory in Kings Mountain. After three years, however, the factory was sold and Mary was laid off. Thus, at the age of sixty-two, she retired, keeping her residence in Kings Mountain. She regained contact with the Smiths, however, and occasionally from 1976 to 1985 she did housework for them when she went to Hickory to visit her family.

Until the early 1990s, Mary continued to work as a domestic a few days a week to supplement her income. However, due to arthritis and failing eyesight, she is no longer able to work. Now, at the age of eighty-nine, Mary collects "whatnots" and enjoys quilting and watching her grandchildren, great-grandchildren, and great-great-grandchildren grow up.

She also enjoys her life at Tate Terrace, although many of her closest friends and neighbors are now deceased. Notably, for the past five years she has been the only African American resident in the community, although in the past there were as many as three African American women and one African American man.

The two rows of apartments that comprise Tate Terrace sit at the bottom of a hill in one of the town's poorer neighborhoods. Each apartment has a small front porch with guardrails and an aluminum-framed screen door. In front of the apartments is a small lawn area dotted with rose bushes and young maple trees. Behind the apartments are four rows of clotheslines that run parallel to a narrow sidewalk. The back porches, which are smaller than the front ones, contain a garbage bin and a conglomeration of different items—chairs, chests, bottles, cans—that the residents have placed there. My grandmother and a few other residents also have planted flowers or tomato plants in front of and behind their apartments.

Before my visit in 1993, the last time I walked along the narrow sidewalk that leads to my grandmother's apartment was in summer 1990. Nonetheless, on this visit I remembered to follow her instructions not to park in Nanna's parking space and to approach her apartment

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from the back, not the front, so that her nosy neighbors would not "know her business." However, no matter her precautions, my grandmother's neighbors always seemed to know when she had company. Life at Tate Terrace is marked by a set of issues, rituals, and "rules," including parking spaces contested by folks who cannot drive or do not own cars; a preoccupation with each other's lives, especially on occasions when visitors are present; and the constant acts of politesse in face-to-face encounters followed by swearing in the privacy of their own apartments—at least in my grandmother's.

A few people have died since my last visit, while others, as ill as they may be, rebuke death whenever it comes calling. The folks of Tate Terrace know that their lives are drawing to a close, and their aches and pains, multiple bottles of medicine, and forgetfulness serve as constant reminders. Yet, there is something in the way that Ruby smiles at me, or the way Claudine cocks her head when she tells me lies about herself or her neighbors, that suggests to me that life, or living, occupies these people's minds and time more so than death.[21] Perhaps the presence of an outsider offers these people an audience for their performances. Their behavior becomes a "show," as my grandmother says, that is as involving, complicated, and entertaining as performances produced for the stage or in motion pictures.

Living in this community, among these people, is where my grandmother feels most comfortable. Her relationships with her neighbors designate her as special and, to a certain extent, confirm that she is in control of her life. How ironic that my brother called me on the first night of my visit in 1993 to try to convince me to persuade my grandmother to move to Hickory to live with family.[22] It was ironic because on this same night I realized how much my grandmother is needed at Tate Terrace and how much the community is a part of her. In fact, it is, so it seems, centered on her. All of the residents know and respect her. For instance, during my stay a number of residents came to her for advice, others to borrow food items, and one to borrow money. In addition, she mediated disputes between feuding residents. Also, her apartment is located in the center of the community and, therefore, she is audience to most of the dramatic events of the day. Thus, in many ways my grandmother feels more needed by the residents of Tate Terrace than by her own family, who have their own lives and

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families. Her family does not depend on her as do the folks of Tate Terrace.

When my grandmother visits with her children she lacks the autonomy and self-reliance she has at home. Her children and grandchildren feel the need to protect her because of her age. Although she is not resentful of such attention my grandmother is too independent to be ruled by her children. At Tate Terrace she enjoys her independence and freedom to come and go as she pleases. She enjoys the control she has over her life and, to a certain extent, over the lives of others.

She also enjoyed the autonomy that she experienced working in the Smiths' household. Five days out of the week, my grandmother was left alone and in charge of the Smiths' home and their four children. The autonomy, authority, and control that she experienced during the week at the Smiths seems to have carried over into how she lives her life at Tate Terrace.

On the third day of my visit in 1993 my grandmother told me that she wanted to perform her narrative. The way she communicated this desire suggested that she did not look forward to telling me about her life as a domestic. She would much rather talk about the people of Tate Terrace. Three years earlier I had interviewed her as part of a project for graduate school.[23] At the time she was excited and eager and she could not wait to tell me stories about Claudine and her grandchildren, as well as about her other friends at Tate Terrace. In those stories, my grandmother was always the one who was smarter than everyone else—the trickster. I can only assume that she felt that her stories about being a domestic would cast her in a different light—one in which she was no longer the weaver of tales, the joker duping the gullible. Instead, she might have seen herself as the trickster whose "tricks" were matters of survival rather than "play." Whatever the reasons, my grandmother's attitude toward talking about her years with the Smiths influenced her performance style. It was stiff, reserved, and formal. I found I had to work hard as an interviewer to obtain information. Most of her answers to my questions were short and to the point unless something I asked or she said sparked a fond memory, at which point she would elaborate and tell a more detailed or exclusive story.

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Performing Domestic Labor: "Making Do" and Remaking Blackness

I wish to draw here on Mary Rhyne's narrative to identify how she views, constructs, and performs the role of domestic laborer. I compare and contrast her perspective with that of other fictional and nonfictional texts concerned with the black American female laborer in the United States in the twentieth century. In addition to analyzing the narrated events that Mary recounts, I frequently address how Mary performs her labor history in the "present," in the narrative situation. Whereas in the past events Mary frequently constructs a persona who "makes do" within the site and in light of the rules of her employer's home, it is by means of her present performance that Mary remakes her (or the) identity of the domestic laborer. If for no other reason than that Mary speaks (speaks to and about her experiences as a domestic laborer), performance becomes a site where a typically silent, or silenced, part of our history is given voice.

As articulated by Mary in her narrative, four key characteristics of her domestic labor experience stand out. First, the work was physically demanding and the pay was low. Second, in lieu of sufficient monetary compensation for the work that she performed, nonmonetary forms of "compensation" became part of the employer-employee contract. In addition to receiving material goods (i.e., hand-me-downs), Mary felt that because the Smiths were "*very* nice people" who treated her with respect, the job was worth keeping. As I discuss below, this exchange of physical labor for "nice" treatment presupposed that Mary would also be "nice" to the Smith family. Based on the experiences that Mary recounts, I interpret the term "nice" to reflect a mutual understanding between her and the Smiths concerning her position within the home and her relationship to the family. In brief, she was an "outsider-within." On one level, she was treated as an adult member of the family and she claimed authority (and responsibilities) accordingly. On another level, however, her "familial" position and authority was constantly qualified by the fact that she was a paid employee and she was black. She was clearly not a member of the family and any claim to authority was in deference to that of her employers.

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Third, my grandmother took pride in her work. In her narrative, she explicitly highlights her culinary talents and skills. She implies that her knowledge and experience in raising children is and was superior to that of Mrs. Smith. And she boasts of her honesty. According to Mary, because she was "a l w a y s honest," she "COULD ALWAYS GET UH JOB." Finally, my grandmother's narrative demonstrates how her experiences as a domestic influence her present life and relationships at Tate Terrace. In particular, she identifies herself as part of what she terms the "*sick* group" and yet also as one of its caretakers.

Before I discuss these four characteristics of domestic labor as articulated by and emphasized in Mary's narrative, I wish to offer one caveat about my analysis of her narrative. Namely, in general terms, a number of contemporary theories concerned with race, gender, age, and class systems enable me to identify and interpret my grandmother and her experiences in terms of her being part of an oppressed and victimized group of people. And, in my analysis, I do at times claim and specifically pursue this perspective. What my grandmother says in her narrative, however, contradicts this perspective. In other words, she does not view herself as oppressed. Or, more specifically, domestic labor was not, for her, oppression. It was a job—work that she did, and did well, in order to support and nurture what was far more important to her and her identity, that is, her own life, home, and family.

In so saying, I do not intend to inscribe my grandmother as "unique" within the domestic labor force nor as an icon of "motherly" sacrifice. Rather, I intend to point out that my grandmother did not, and does not, identify herself and what she values solely in terms of domestic work and a white family and its worldview. Indeed, her refusal to be labeled "oppressed" suggests a detachment from or an indifference toward the labor site that may well be more resistant, or resistant in a different way, than those strategies that grant the "oppressor" the authority she or he assumes or desires.

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"Ah Done Ol' an' Broke Down": The Physical Hardships and Low Pay of Domestic Work

Mary's narrative defines, if nothing else, domestic work as physically and emotionally challenging: hard on the body and on the mind. Her tale relates long days of cooking, cleaning the house, washing and ironing clothes, and tending to the children. She also talks about both the temporary and long-term effects that the labor has had on her body.

At several points in the narrative Mary speaks briefly of her chores. She began her workday by preparing breakfast for the Smiths, followed by washing and ironing clothes, cleaning the eight-room house, and preparing dinner. In addition to these chores, Mary relates that she was responsible for seeing the children off to school and to church. She maintained this routine for over eighteen years.

The amount and kind of work my grandmother was expected to do in the Smiths' home is characteristic of domestic work in general. In addition, the domestic's daily schedule is frequently filled with more work than can be accomplished in a single day by a single laborer. Washing, ironing, and folding a week's laundry for an entire family, preparing meals, taking care of the children, and completing "special" projects such as cleaning the closets or attic suggests an intense schedule. And, as Mrs. Smith acknowledged in her conversation with me, my grandmother appears to have followed such a schedule: "So, she just got in there and she did the cooking and taking care of the kids and I think running day, morning to night."[24]

In Rollins's study of domestic workers, one participant, Julia Henry, states that many women choose to quit rather than meet the demands of the job. She recounts: "It was too much work from the beginning. It was two day's work in one. I was washing clothes, ironing. Then I had to do two bathrooms, three bedrooms, vacuum. I'd be so tired. I'd come home. I couldn't go anywhere except to bed. It really wasn't worth it. I told her [the employer] I couldn't do it all in one day. I finally left."[25] Although, like Julia Henry, Mary disliked housework that was physically taxing, in the episode of her narrative "As Long as Ah Stay Black" she states that she didn't mind housework "if it ain't / lot uh

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dat ol' / washin' an' ahrnin'." In other words, she did not seem to mind housework if it were not overly taxing, or at least if she were able to do tasks that she enjoyed, such as cooking. Some of her dislike of housework was due to her having to use poor equipment or, in the case of dishwashing, no equipment at all. Rollins confirms in her study that "dilapidated, outdated, or very cheap equipment [forced] the worker to compensate for its ineffectiveness with extra physical effort" (69).

In the episode "Dey Nevah Was Too Much Trouble," grandmother contrasts the pleasure she and the Smiths derived from her culinary skills with her displeasure in having to wash all the dishes by hand. Grandmother says:

> dey l o v e d squash casserole
> Ah'd fix dat
> Ah/was/all/de/time/makin'/som'in'
> yeah dey liked what Ah cooked
> dey loved mah *cookin'*—
> fo' dey got uh dishwasher
> Ah washed dishes everyday__—
> dey looked
> Mrs. uh
> Mrs.
> Grandmama say
>
> (switches to old, decrepit voice)
>
> "Ah 'clare"
> say
> "one of dese days yuh jus' look out ovah deah"
> say
> "jus' look in dat windah
> she'll be standin' in dat windah
> washin' dishes"__
>
> (smiles)
>
> Ah thought
> not ef dey had uh *dish*washer

While Mrs. Smith's mother, "Mrs. Grandmama," romanticizes the image of Mary "standin' in dat window/washin' dishes," Mary signifies on the woman by stating "Ah thought / not ef dey had uh *dish*washer."

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Rather than vocalize to her employers her dislike of washing dishes by hand (a complaint for which she might have been reprimanded), she uses indirection (silence) in the narrated event and verbal Signifyin' in the narrative event. Mary makes it known, then, that while she enjoyed cooking the physical labor of having to cook *and* clean up by hand was not, as "Mrs. Grandmama" would like to configure it, an ideal experience. In other words, in her performance of the past events Mary refuses to adhere to the "Stepin Fetchit" prototype of mammy. She recodes, or clarifies the duplicitous coding of, a happy mammy washing dishes by offering her own contradictory view of the situation.

One aspect of Mary's physical labor that is more difficult for her to recode by means of performance is the long-term effects that the work has had on her body. Mary's hands are burned and scarred from cooking, and she presently experiences severe hip and back pain due to the years that she spent on her feet. In addition, as she explains in the episode "Oh Dey Nice People," the combined effect of living in a "mill house" and working in the Smiths' house is that she now suffers from arthritis in her legs:

> an' d e n
> an' d e n
> Ah got
> Ah tol' dat Ah had tuh have uh *house*—
> DAT'S/HOW/COME/MY/LEGS/LIKE/DEY/IS
> my arthritis
> dis is all from de *mill* houses
> dese ain't nuthin' but mill floors
> dese ol' cement floors
> my legs[26]

Mary's "ol' an' broke down" physical condition is not uncommon to domestic workers. Rollins confirms that the older domestics in her study "had various physical ailments associated with their work: lower back problems, varicose veins, and most common, ankle and foot problems."[27]

Until the early 1990s, despite her physical condition, Mary continued to do housework for Mrs. Smith and others. Although she con-

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tended that she could not "do uh w h o l e lot of *hard* work" when, as she states, "my hip don't hurt meh so bad," she did accommodate the various requests for light housework. The pay she received supplemented her income and, as I discuss later in the chapter, until Mary was physically unable to do so, there appeared to be an implicit assumption on the part of Mrs. Smith that Mary would always be available, and able, to tend to her home. And, although Mary often said it "ain't worth" it, she regularly chose to fulfill Mrs. Smith's and her other employers' expectations.

One of the most disheartening aspects concerning domestic work is the pay. According to Rollins, between 1960 and 1980 many domestics who worked ten- and twelve-hour days often were paid as little as thirty dollars a week. Live-in domestics, who were essentially at work twenty-four hours a day, were paid even less (72–75). Marva Woods, a live-in domestic in Rollins's study, tells of how she was paid as little as thirty-seven dollars a week:

> I just worked until I got the children to bed. Every Thursday and every other Sunday was off. I got up in the morning, fixed breakfast, got the children ready for school, and carried little John to nursery school. I'd get them all off then start doing my housework: the washing, cleaning up. John would come home about twelve. I'd go and get him and give him his lunch and put him to bed. I would iron or something while he was in bed. When he got up, I'd take him for a walk. Then I'd cook dinner and serve it. After I cleaned up the kitchen and got the children to bed, I was finished. . . . She started me off at thirty-seven dollars a week, then she gave me a raise and I was making fifty-five dollars. (71)

Marva Woods's workday resembles that of Mary's, although Mary did not have fixed days off and, as she states in her account, she was paid only twenty-five dollars a week. Rollins admits that live-in pay is more difficult to measure due to the nonmonetary compensation that the domestic receives, such as meals and a room of her own. Nonetheless, the highest estimates for live-in work that Rollins obtained (from agencies in Boston) were one hundred to one hundred seventy-five dollars a week (74–75).

Mary also never received monetary benefits such as vacation pay or bonuses. In fact, when I asked her if she had ever received a bonus, she found my question ridiculous:

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DID THEY EVER GIVE YOU A BONUS AT CHRISTMAS OR ANYTHING LIKE THAT?

(abruptly)

naw

(looks at me and sneers and begins to laugh)

what?^^

(more laughing)

what kind uh *BONUS*?

(turns her head away from me)

no
no bonus
Ah didn't git no bonus—

Although Mary did not receive monetary bonuses of any kind, she was and is fortunate that the Smiths deducted social security from her pay. Following her retirement Mary's main source of income was her social security check. According to Mary, the woman who followed her in service at the Smiths' home was not so fortunate:

THEY DIDN'T HIRE ANYBODY AFTER YOU?

yeah dey got somebody
dey got somebody tuh work fuh 'em
an' dey didn't
take out de woman's
social security
social security or some'in' or another
an'
Ms. Smith had tuh pay back uh lot uh dat social security
. . . . . .
so
Ah thank she went tuh go draw huh lil' social security
say

(giggles)

dey hadn't took none out on 'uh
an' see dey got on tuh Mrs. Smith nem

(crosses her legs)

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an' dey had tuh pay all dat *back*
had tuh pay dat
had tuh pay it
you know dey s'ppose tuh take out social security on yuh
everywhere you *work*
dey-didn't-take-it-out-on-'uh

The Smiths' actions are, apparently, commonplace. According to Rollins, "In domestic service, non-compliance with Social Security legislation is rampant" (76).[28]

Throughout her telling of the various stories that dealt with the physical aspects and demands of domestic work, Mary supported her verbal account with nonverbal performance. Whether by means of closing her eyes, mixing and stirring "imaginary" ingredients, or pointing to parts of her body, Mary used her body in ways that are discursive, in ways that paint a portrait of her life as a domestic as *she* sees it. Moreover, her incorporation of the body provides the interpreter of her narrative with images—however fleeting—that facilitate a point of entry into the performance and domestic sites of narration.

Most commonly, Mary used repetitive and rhythmic physical movements to communicate the work that she did. On the one hand, her repetition of certain actions served as a metaphor for what she viewed as redundant work. On the other hand, her use of repetition directly denoted, or illustrated, the fact that the work was repetitious. Not only did it effect a repetitive sensation or quality, it was repetitive. For example, in the episode "Dey Didn't Pay Nuthin'" Mary uses nonverbal repetition to augment or accent her repetitive, verbal listing of the chores. Each time she says "an' den Ah'd fix," her hands rise up, and on the word that follows, whether it be "dinnah" or "suppah," her hands fall in a prancing motion. The up-and-down physical movement and accentuation of the words produce a "rhythmic-iconic coding."[29] The motions do not convey word content as much as they convey rhythmic content—that is, the repetitive rhythm of the work.

In her performance, Mary frequently pointed to her body to emphasize a particular verbal point. In other words, she used nonverbal discourse to direct attention to her corporeal body. In "Dey Didn't Pay Nuthin'" Mary relates how she received third-degree burns on her hand from a grease fire in the Smiths's kitchen. She recalls:

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dey/put/me/in/de/hospital
dey took ca'uh of d a t
an'
dem s c a r s deah

(points to her left hand and makes a circling motion)

Ah got all dat burned off
a l l dat deah
all dat was cooked/all dat just cooked
so
it took me uh l o n g time tuh get up
so
dey had tuh take ca'uh of all uh dat

By pointing to the scars on her hand, Mary supports the fact that she was burned. Her illustration lends credibility to her verbal account. The scars also mark her body as a historical text, a discursive site where the past experience is retold in and through the present performance. As Carol Stern and Bruce Henderson explain, "the body creates language and participates in its performance simultaneously."[30]

In this case, the body language and its performance produce duplicitous meanings.[31] The scars reference the labor site, her work and its damaging effect. The past labor site permanently claims, marks, and disfigures the body. Simultaneously, Mary's public display of the scars speaks against, or defiles, the domestic site. In Mikhail Bakhtin's terms, her "grotesque" body degrades any reading of the past site (and her body) that would tend toward a "high, spiritual, ideal, abstract" conception of them.[32] Although "the essential principle of grotesque realism is degradation" (17), according to Bakhtin, degradation "is always conceiving" (19). It works to reposition the high and the ideal in "contact with [the] earth as an element that swallows up and gives birth at the same time" (21). As Peter Stallybrass and Allon White remind us: "The grotesque physical body is invoked both defensively and offensively because it is not simply a powerful image but fundamentally constitutive of the categorical sets through which we live and make sense of the world."[33]

In this case, Mary shows her scars to defend her account, as if to say "look what the work did to me." She took the offense in that her physical display criticizes the past event. By means of performance,

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then, the performer rewrites her body—she assigns it new or additional meanings. The meanings do not idealize the body, however; indeed, it is precisely because the body itself is not idealized that the past (Mary's history as a domestic) cannot be idealized either. Performance permits Mary to show the grotesque body as the "body in the act of becoming." "The grotesque body continually builds and creates another body."[34]

Authorizing Power: "Like One of the Family"

Although Mary never complained to the Smiths about the low pay that she received for the amount of work that she did, she was well aware of the inequity. She was conscious of her hard work as well as her indispensability. In the episode "Ah'd Cut de Grass" when I asked her "What would they have done if you hadn't been there?" she gave the following response:

n o
they wouldn't have *done*
dat's what everybody say__
good Lord
L O R D/Ah say
dey ought tuh have paid me uh thousand dollahs uh week
'cause see Ah stayed—
YOU/HEAH/ME/SAY/AH/STAYED/DEAH/AN'/TOOK/CARE
UH/DEM/*CHAPS*
an'
an' dey was down yondah in
in *SHELBY*
an' wouldn't nobody else
nobody else

(fold her arms)

wouldn't nobody else stay deah an—
day an' night an' take care uh dem chil'ren like *Ah'd* do it
. . . . . .
Ah did uh w h o l e lot of work fuh dem
dey oughten nevah forget me

(shakes her head)

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DEY OUGHTEN *NEVAH*
'cause Ah s h o' saved dem uh many time
many uh time

In lieu of monetary compensation, Mary expects that "dey oughten nevah forget me . . . DEY OUGHTEN *NEVAH*." And, indeed, in her comments to me, Mrs. Smith clearly has not forgotten Mary (or, as Mrs. Smith refers to her, "Daisy"). Mrs. Smith appears to realize the quality of Mary's service to her when she reflects, "Everybody says, 'Oh we won't have another Daisy. You won't find another Daisy.' " After her retirement, then, it is the fact of being remembered for her years of service that is important to Mary, whereas earlier her employer's "nice" treatment of her appears to compensate for the "hard work."

In what follows, I discuss the various episodes in Mary's narrative that deal with what, as compared to the hard-work/low-pay characteristic, appears to me to be a more subjective component of the domestic contract. In brief, I discuss the unwritten interpersonal contract that Mary continually alludes to in her narrative. I describe what constitutes this contract and how Mary adhered, or did not adhere, to the unstated expectations by consciously and unconsciously donning the mammy mask. Ultimately, the point I wish to communicate is twofold: on the one hand "authentic" blackness is constructed by Mary's white mistress vis-à-vis her construal of what a "real good mammy" should be. Mary performs and obliges that construction in various ways. On the other hand, within her narrative performance, she also performs her own version of "authentic" blackness by drawing on black cultural performance traditions that reposition and ground her authority as a "black" subject.

As described earlier, for twenty-five dollars a week Mrs. Smith expected Mary to prepare meals, clean the eight-room house, and provide care for the four children. For reasons that seem inadequate, Mrs. Smith offered Mary other nonmonetary forms of compensation: her own bedroom, free movement through the house, a place at the dinner table, and gifts and hand-me-downs. When Mrs. Smith cleaned out her closets or garage, Mary usually had first choice of the clothes or items to be given away. She would then bring these goods home to her children and grandchildren. Mary received items such as televisions, armchairs, lamps, coffee tables, and clothes. After her family

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took what they wanted, Mary shared the leftovers with our neighbors. This practice went on for years and saved my mother and her siblings a considerable amount of money. Moreover, it was a way for Mary to provide for her family. Although she could not always be there for them physically or emotionally, she was materially and financially supportive of her own children.

Mary was also permitted to move about the Smiths' home as she pleased—even when the Smiths were home she had free reign in the house. And, unlike most domestics, she ate in the dining room with her employers. One of her fondest memories is having Christmas dinner with the Smiths, which she describes in the episode "Every Chris'mas." During that memory, she recalls where everyone sat, including herself:

> den
> everybody had tuh come in the dining room
>
> (spreads her arms to show the size of the table)
>
> round de big family table
> everybody be sittin' deah
> 'round dat table
> so
> Dr. Niles
>
> (points to each place each person would be around the table)
>
> he'd be right heah at *dis* end
> an' Ah'd be right *heah*
> Mrs. Smith would be right *deah*
> Mr. Smith would be right *deah*
> an' de othah chil'ren 'round
> everybody sittin' 'round dat table
> an' Dr. Niles would
> would as'
>
> (closes her eyes)
>
> de blessin'
> he would as' one of de sweetes' blessin's__
> so
> everybody would eat
> *Chris'mas*
> an' Ah'd he'p tuh *cook*

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In relation to accounts offered in other studies, the image my grandmother paints here is not a common one. For example, traditionally most domestics were allowed only to serve food but never to sit down to eat with their employers. Moreover, many domestics were not permitted to move about the house freely but instead were relegated to the kitchen. Because the kitchen is where most domestics did much of their work, most were expected to remain there even when not on duty. Relegating servants to the kitchen was common; there their employers would be able to exert physical as well as psychological control.[35] Another anomalous "perk" permitted my grandmother but not most other domestics was having a "room of her own," which was located on the same floor as the children's rooms. Unlike my grandmother's situation, most live-in domestics' sleeping arrangements ranged, according to David Katzman, from "a third-story attic filled with worn out family furniture" to a room "with hardly more space than a closet," to no room at all.[36]

In my interview with Mrs. Smith, she offers that, prior to Mary's employ, she (Mrs. Smith) was looking for "a good mammy." "I wants me a real mammy," she said. And because Mary worked for Mrs. Smith for eighteen years, apparently Mary fulfilled Mrs. Smith's requirements. In light of what Mary recounts, Mrs. Smith expected a "real mammy" to do a large amount of work for little pay. To compensate, Mrs. Smith rewarded "Daisy" with material gifts and hand-me-downs, a nice room, free reign of the house, and a seat at the family dinner table. In other words, for Mrs. Smith a "real mammy" is or becomes "one of the family." And this interpersonal "reward" appears to be primary to the contract that Mrs. Smith and Mary "negotiated."

In so saying, I do not intend to inscribe Mrs. Smith as a lone agent. Her personalization of the economic (and political) aspects of domestic work was, and is, common to our mass culture. Regardless of race or gender, people who do housework and/or care for children are not paid well. The "domestication" of domestic work functions to contain the labor in the home site, and thereby its economic operations can be privatized, disassociated from the public marketplace and its regulations. As a result, and throughout our social history, women (and, more recently, men) who work in the home are either not paid or are paid very little. As with the contract agreed upon by Mrs. Smith and Mary, personalized forms of compensation are substituted for equi-

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table pay (e.g., "gifts" from the breadwinner, unmonitored time in the home, and the understanding that tending to children is self-fulfilling in itself).

To the extent that Mrs. Smith constructs authentic blackness as the ability and *willingness* to perform as a "real mammy," however, her authority within her household and within her relationship with my grandmother maintains the racist hierarchy placed on the value of "black" as opposed to "white" bodies and labor reflected in larger society. Regarding the interpersonal contract arranged between the employer and employee, then, benevolence (being nice) compensates for low pay, and it is to be repaid by the expectation that the domestic is to fulfill the "outsider-within," "family/not-family" role as given.

The contradictions inherent in this role were, in the 1960s, apparent on a broader social-cultural level as well. As my grandmother relates in the episode "Ain't Nuthin' but uh Sick Group" that she had to ride in the back of the bus when using public transportation and, yet, it was also commonplace for her to bathe the Smith children. That is, as the Smiths' maid and nanny she entered public places that were otherwise barred to her. The social restrictions on blacks, as compared to blacks-as-servants, were not uncommon in the South—and, I suspect, in other regions of the country as well.[37]

My grandmother appears to have variously adhered to the "mammy" contract I discussed above. At times, her adherence appears genuine. She played the role in goodwill and/or out of pride in doing "GOOD HONES' HARD WORK." Other times she "made do" by covertly finding a way to subvert the contract in order to service her own needs or desires. In other words, she appropriated the "white" construction of the mammy and used it to her own "black" advantage.

In the episode "Dey Nevah Was Too Much Trouble," Mary conforms to the prototypical mammy figure in that she constructs an image of herself as a caretaker who loved tending to her white charges. She insists that the children "nevah was too much trouble," although elsewhere in that episode Jimmy appears to have been quite a handful. The youngest child, Carol, is clearly Mary's favorite and, as the following excerpt suggests, eventually leaving Carol was very difficult:

> Ca'uh was uh different story/she was *so* sweet
>
> (closes her eyes)

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Jimmy Smith, age five.

Carol Smith, age three.

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Ah jus'
L o r d Ah jus' love dat lil' ol' youngin' tuh death
Ah hated tuh leave—
Ah had tuh cry one day
Ah/jus'/hated/tuh/leave/Ca'uh
Ah jus' had got attached tuh Ca'uh 'cause she was jus' uh sweet lil' ol'
youngin'

Mary's seeming adoration of Carol and her general coddling attitude toward the other children are attitudes not uncommon to domestics, real or fictional. In Toni Morrison's *The Bluest Eye,* for example, the character Pauline Breedlove dotes on her employer's little girl very much like Mary fawns over Carol when Carol wears the hat "wit' one of dem lil' ol' ribbons in it" to church. Morrison writes: "When [Pauline] bathed the little Fisher girl, it was in a porcelain tub with silvery taps running infinite quantities of hot, clear water. She dried her in fluffy white towels and put her in cuddly night clothes. Then she brushed the yellow hair, enjoying the roll and slip of it between her fingers. No zinc tub, no buckets of stove-heated water, no flaky, stiff, grayish towels washed in a kitchen sink, dried in a dusty backyard, no tangled black puffs of rough wool to comb."[38] Pauline's love and affection for her employer's child, however, is often to the neglect and ill treatment of her own children. In doing so, Pauline perpetuates the stereotype of the overprotective mammy whose primary concern is the welfare of her white employers' children. As Harris observes, Pauline "becomes another example of the maid who cannot effect an acceptable compromise between the kind of work she does and the person she is."[39]

Although my grandmother pampered the Smith children but was unable to spend the amount of time she would have liked with her own children, she did not to my knowledge physically abuse her children. Rather, to compensate for the lack of time she made sure that they were provided for in other ways. She used her leverage with the Smiths to make her children's lives more comfortable, such as when she accepted the hand-me-downs that her employers gave her. Grandmother's acceptance of the Smiths' leftovers speaks to her need to substantiate her income. To do this, she played the "outsider-within" role as contracted: she gratefully accepted the "gifts" from her employers. Then, when with her own family, she would turn her attention to what to do with what were, in actuality, "leftovers."

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Mary, holding Carol Smith, 1959.

In the episode "Oh Dey Nice People" my grandmother explains how she informed the Smiths that if she could not find a house for herself with wood floors, she could not work for them any longer. Her rationale was that the apartment in which she lived had cement floors that hurt her legs. In this case, grandmother's explanation disguised an additional motive. At the time she had two sons who lived in poor housing conditions and were struggling with rent. They needed a better and cheaper place to live. Grandmother was aware that the Smiths owned several houses in the poor black neighborhood where she and my mother lived. Behind my mother's apartment was a small white house with wood floors that the Smiths owned. So, my grandmother prodded the Smiths into renting the house to her, which she then in turn shared with her sons. By means of indirection, then, my grandmother got her wood floors; my uncles, a better place to live; and the Smiths held on to their "Daisy" by helping her out.

Although these gifts may inscribe the dominant/subordinate relationship between the employer and her employee in terms of the gift giving being, in Rollins's words, a "statement to the servant of what kinds of material goods the employer considers appropriate for her,"[40]

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APPENDIX A

Mary Rhyne's Narrative

As stated in chapter 4, I have chosen to include Mary's narrative in its entirety to contextualize my analysis and to allow Mary to "speak" for herself. The narrative is divided into episodes and each is titled thematically throughout the longer narrative. The narrative transcription also highlights Mary's body movements from which I infer meaning in relation to what she narrates. The translation of the poetic transcription symbols is as follows:

The end of a poetic line represents a half-second pause. A period (.) represents at least a two-second pause. A solidus (/) between words with no space represents words spoken so rapidly together that they are all pronounced as one word. Capital letters represent an increase in volume. A dash (—) represents an abrupt shift or change in theme. Spacing between letters in a word represents a deliberate slowing down to emphasize each sound in the word for effect (example: He needs p l e n t y help*). An arrowhead pointing up (^) represents a rise in voice pitch after each word; two arrows or more represent a further increase in pitch. A line at the bottom of a word (*so what_*) represents a lowering in voice pitch; two lines or more represent a further decrease in pitch (*so what__*). Angle brackets (<>) between words, phrases, and lines represent the voice whispering; double (or more) brackets represent a quieter whisper (example:* on the road it was <<dark>>*). A word in italics represents an emotional emphasis, an intensity in breath and sound, not volume (example:* I *sacrificed* all my life*). Three periods (. . .) represent a pause while thinking or while contemplating what has just been said. A hyphen between words, phrases, and lines represents mumbling (example:* I-don't-know-what-they-do*).*

The interview took place on Tuesday, May 18, 1993. We had just finished supper and had moved to the living room with our bowls of ice cream. After we ate the

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ice cream, I got out my pad and pencil and tested the tape recorder. Mary did not look at me. Instead, she looked out of the window to her right over which a shade was half pulled. She sat on a green faux-leather couch with floral-print pillows surrounding her. The armrest had a rust-colored crocheted arm cover over it. On the back of the couch was a multicolored crocheted quilt. My grandmother was dressed in her customary polyester cut-off shorts, lime-and-white striped, and a pink polyester blouse. She did not wear a bra or shoes. Loosely tied around her head was a sheer scarf with an apricot flower design on it. After I tested the tape, I sat it on the end table next to her and asked the first question.

Nevah Had uh Cross Word

HOW LONG DID YOU WORK FOR THE SMITHS?

Ah stayed at the Smiths' 'bout
twenty/*nineteen* yeahs.

(10 sec. pause)

When Ah first went there
Ca'uh [Carol] wasn't/born
Jimmy.
was *eight*months ol'.
Eddie was eight *yeah* ol'
and.
Patty was *six* yeah ol'

(looks at me)

and.

(10 sec. pause)

and
Ah stayed deah an
kep' 'em/kept de house/Mrs. Smith 'nem went to
uh
Shelby
an' bought uh
mo'/uh/hotel
down in *Shelby*
bought uh hotel down in Shelby
an' Ah/dey stayed down neah/an' Ah stayed in de house
an' looked at dem *chil'ren*
an Ah sent 'em tuh school

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Ah sent Eddie/Eddie
an Patty went tuh *Appalachian*
tuh *college*
an Ah kep' Jimmy and Ca'uh deah at de house
an' sent dem tuh school
at Oakwood school__

(There is a one-minute pause here. She crosses her right leg over her left, jiggling it while staring out the window)

Ah raised
Ah *raised* dem kids—
did/ever'thang

(30 sec. pause)

WHAT WERE SOME OF THE THINGS YOU DID?

(abruptly)
Oh Ah cleaned *house*.
did all de *wash*in'/an' Mrs. Smith didn't know nothin' 'bout
what de chil'ren *need*
they clothes/an' when dey git out uh clothes/when dey needed somthin'
AH had tuh
tell/'uh
what the chil'ren need—
dresses.
panties/whatever/dey/need/Ah/had/tuh/tell/'uh
she didn't know dat stuff 'cause see
she/wa'n't/*deah*.
wit' de chil'ren.

(15 sec. pause)

HOW OLD WERE THE KIDS?

OK.
Like Ah was tellin' yuh
Ah thought Ah tol' yuh Ca'uh wasn't born__
Jimmy was *eight* months old
an'
Eddie was de ol'est one/he was eight *yeah* old
an' Patty was *six* yeah old
dat's when Ah first went ovah deah—
an' den Ca'uh was born
uh.—

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an' when Ah lef' deah
Ca'uh was
ol' enough/Ca'uh was
sixteen or seventeen/Lord/Ah/done/forgot

(30 sec. pause)

YOU WORKED FOR THE FRIERS TOO?

Yeah
went ovah at Mrs. *Frier's*
Ah worked at Mrs. *Frier's* house
worked for Mrs. Frier
Mr. Frier got *sick*
an' Ah'd leave the Smiths
an' got ovah deah an'
clean/up/an'
rake the y a r d
go out deah an' rake de y a r d
an' Ah w a s h an' *ahrn*
an'
cook
an' clean de house___

THEN YOU WOULD GO BACK OVER TO THE SMITHS?

(cuts me off)
go back ovah to de Smiths—
Mrs. Smith is ol' Mrs. Frier's *daughter*

OH?

uh huh
dat's Mrs. Frier's daughter
dat's/how/come/Ah/did/that
Mrs. Frier's daughter__
so dat's what Ah'd communicate
to de board
but Ah stayed with the Smiths
an' worked fuh huh motha

SO YOU LIVED WITH THEM ALL THE TIME?

(cuts me off again)
ALL THE TIME.
Ah lived wit' the *Smiths* all de time__

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